



selling your home,

Strategy, not luck. *The pre-listing guide.*

BY

Kim Pelham • The Pelham Group NW

14 YEARS IN REAL ESTATE

102.3% sale-to-list ratio



your neighbor in real estate

hey neighbor,

This is what a thoughtful sale could look like.

I have been selling homes for 14 years, in Snohomish County since 2015, brokered by Katrina Eileen out of Everett. I cap my buyer clients at two at a time, which is part of what protects the attention your listing gets. But the ideas in here are not really about me. They are about what works.

I put this together because most sellers I meet have never seen what a careful pre-listing process actually looks like. They have seen agents who show up two weeks before the sign goes in the yard and call it a strategy. Sellers deserve better than that, and so do the homes they have lived in.

So this is the version of "what to expect" I wish every seller in Snohomish County had before their first agent conversation. The 90 days before list. The unsexy parts that actually move the price. How to think about staging. What it costs. What happens after closing day. Whether you and I end up working together or not, the framework is the same.

Read what is useful. Skip what is not. And when you are ready to talk, my number is on the last page.

Kim

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The price is *the whole game*.

Almost every listing problem traces back to a number set in the wrong week. Pricing is not where you start the negotiation. It is the negotiation.

Here is what I see most often. A seller anchors to what a neighbor got six months ago, an agent agrees to it because they want the listing, and the home goes live priced for a market that does not exist anymore. By week three the listing is stale, buyers assume something is wrong with it, and the eventual sale comes in under what an honest number would have produced on day one.

Most of that is preventable. The prep work up front is the difference. A thoughtful pricing conversation starts with real comps (closed in the last 45 days, in the same submarket, accounting for view, lot, and condition) and an in-person walk-through of the home before any number ends up on paper. The goal is to land on what the house actually appraises against today, not what it could have last spring.

102.3%

MY SALE-TO-LIST RATIO

100.2%

SNOHOMISH COUNTY AVG

"Pricing ego is the only thing slowing sellers down right now. The good inventory still moves quickly, when the number is right."

Source: NWMLS closed transactions, Snohomish County, trailing 12 months. Kim Pelham personal production figures based on Kim's closed sides during the same period. Past performance does not guarantee future results.

One thing worth holding on to: the first 14 days of a listing are the most valuable window you will have. Every buyer watching the area sees you in that window. If the price is wrong, the window closes. If the price is right, you can end up with competing offers, which is most of where that 102.3% comes from. Not from listing high. From listing honestly, and letting demand do the rest.

The *90 days* before we list.

A good listing is not a sprint at the end. It is a sequence. Here is what it looks like when it is run well.

T-90

3 MONTHS OUT

Walk-through and honest assessment

I come over, we go room by room. I tell you what to fix, what to leave alone, what to declutter, and what to spend money on. I also pull early comps so we can talk about a price band, not a number yet.

T-60

2 MONTHS OUT

Pre-listing inspection & sewer scope

We get ahead of every surprise a buyer's inspector would find. Roof, foundation, electrical, plumbing, sewer line. Fixing what is fixable now beats negotiating it on the back end.

T-30

1 MONTH OUT

Repairs, paint, decluttering

Contractors lined up. Walls get a fresh neutral coat where it matters. We clear half of what is on every shelf. Garage gets emptied of anything that does not need to be in the photos.

T-14

2 WEEKS OUT

Staging weekend & photography

I stage with my own pieces (sofas, art, lamps, rugs) over a weekend. Photographer comes the following Tuesday morning, golden hour. Drone shots if the lot calls for it. Twilights if the view does.

T-7

1 WEEK OUT

MLS prep, disclosures, pricing call

We finalize the price with the most recent week of comps. I write the listing copy. You sign disclosures. We coordinate the live date for a Thursday or Friday to maximize weekend traffic.

Day 0

LIVE ON MLS

Listing goes live · open house weekend

Hits MLS Thursday morning. Open house Saturday and Sunday, twelve to three. I sit them both. By Sunday evening we know if we are reviewing offers Monday.

The *unsexy stuff* that decides every sale.

Buyers fall in love with the kitchen. They walk away because of the roof. We get every one of these in front of you before they get in front of a buyer's inspector.

PRE-LISTING INSPECTION

- ☐ Roof age, condition, and remaining life
- ☐ Attic ventilation and insulation
- ☐ Crawlspace, foundation, drainage
- ☐ Electrical panel and amperage
- ☐ Plumbing supply lines and water heater age
- ☐ Sewer scope to the city main
- ☐ Furnace, ducts, and filter condition
- ☐ Windows, seals, and visible flashing

REPAIRS I USUALLY RECOMMEND

- ☐ Replace any failed window seals (cheap, obvious to buyers)
- ☐ Service the furnace and clean ducts
- ☐ Caulk and re-grout bathrooms thoroughly
- ☐ Fix every running toilet and slow drain
- ☐ Touch up paint at door frames and baseboards
- ☐ Power wash siding, walkways, deck
- ☐ Replace any burnt-out bulbs (every one)
- ☐ Address pet smells before staging, not after

DOCUMENTS I WILL GATHER FOR YOU

- ☐ Form 17 seller disclosure (every line walked through)
- ☐ Permit history for any work done
- ☐ HOA documents, CC&Rs, dues, reserves
- ☐ Most recent property tax statement
- ☐ Survey or plat map if available
- ☐ Warranties on roof, HVAC, appliances
- ☐ Septic records, if applicable
- ☐ Mineral, water, and easement disclosures

REPAIRS I WILL TELL YOU TO SKIP

- ☐ Full kitchen or bath remodels (you won't recoup)
- ☐ Carpet replacement if the existing is clean
- ☐ New appliances unless the current ones are broken
- ☐ Driveway resurfacing unless cracked through
- ☐ Roof replacement if 5+ years of life remain
- ☐ Landscaping beyond mulch, mow, and edging
- ☐ Bedroom paint colors that already read neutral
- ☐ Anything cosmetic that a buyer will want to redo

What *good staging* looks like.

Staging is not decoration. It is the bridge between how you live in your house and how a buyer pictures themselves living there. Five rooms do almost all of the work.



pieces chosen for the room, not wheeled in from a warehouse

Rental staging is fine, and it works well for vacant homes. For lived-in homes, the best results usually come from pieces selected specifically for the room (sofas, rugs, art, lamps, books) chosen for the way the home photographs. I stage every one of my listings myself, with pieces I have collected over the years for exactly this work.

The goal is not "Pinterest perfect." The goal is a buyer pausing at the threshold of every room and picturing themselves there.

The consultation is on me. I walk every room and leave you with a written plan, no charge. Hands-on staging is charged separately: roughly \$1,000 to \$1,800 occupied, \$2,500 and up vacant, depending on the size of the house, how much furniture we bring in, and the logistics. I keep it low on purpose, and unlike a staging company I do not charge a monthly furniture rental fee, which commonly runs \$800 to \$2,000 a month. Most sellers earn it back many times over.

THE 5 ROOMS THAT DECIDE IT

- 01 **Living room.** A single conversation grouping, one anchor rug, no more than three pieces of art on any wall. Buyers stand here longest.
- 02 **Kitchen.** Counters cleared to two intentional objects. Cabinet contents reduced by half. Pendant bulbs matching, warm white.
- 03 **Primary bedroom.** Bed made hotel-style, two nightstands matching, lamps on, blinds tilted up. Closets must look half-empty.
- 04 **Primary bath.** Towels rolled, mirror perfect, two products visible total. No personal medication, no clutter on the back of the toilet.
- 05 **Front porch & entry.** The first 8 seconds of every showing. Doormat, planter, paint touched up, working light, swept walk.

What it *actually costs* to sell.

A good sale comes with no surprises at closing. Here is what comes out of your proceeds, with realistic ranges for a Snohomish County sale around the county median.

LINE ITEM	TYPICAL RANGE
Listing brokerage commission Negotiated up front. We discuss this on call one. No surprises.	Negotiated
Buyer's agent compensation Post-2024 rule changes. May be paid by buyer, seller, or split. We strategize.	Negotiated
Excise tax (WA state) Tiered: 1.10% to 3.00% depending on sale price.	1.10 to 3.00%
Title insurance & escrow Owner's title policy + escrow fees.	\$1,800 to \$3,200
Pre-listing inspection & sewer scope Recommended. Both standard in this market. Saves more than they cost in nine out of ten sales.	\$625 to \$925
Photography & marketing Listing photos, MLS prep, twilights, drone, and video where the home calls for it. I cover this on every listing I take.	Included
Staging Free consult with a room-by-room plan. Hands-on staging optional. Can be deferred to closing.	Free consult, \$1,000–\$1,800 occupied, \$2,500+ vacant
Repairs & concessions (varies) Negotiated after inspection. The pre-listing inspection minimizes this.	0.5 to 1.5%

my promise.

Before we sign anything, you get a written net-sheet showing your estimated proceeds at three different sale prices. You will know your bottom number before the sign goes in the yard. If something does shift between list and close, you hear about it from me first, not from a closing statement.

your next chapter.

When you are ready, *I have your back.*

I keep my buyer roster small, two at a time by design, so the listings I take always have the front of my calendar. If we are going to work together I want to make sure the fit is right for both of us. The first conversation is twenty minutes, on your couch or on the phone. No pitch, no pressure, no agenda. Just questions.

THE FIRST CALL

PHONE & TEXT

425-250-9422

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SERVING

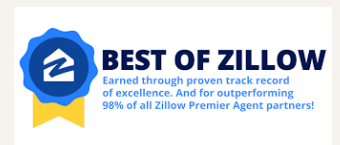
Everett · Bothell · Mill Creek

Snohomish · Lake Stevens · Marysville ·

Mukilteo

Kim

your neighbor in real estate



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